



Signs of Labor

How to know when it's time to head to the hospital

What happens when labor begins

As labor begins, the cervix opens (dilates). The uterus, which contains muscle, contracts at regular intervals. When it contracts, the

abdomen becomes hard. Between the contractions, the uterus relaxes and becomes soft. Up to the start of labor and during early labor,

the baby will continue to move.

Certain changes also may signal that labor is beginning. You may or may not notice some of them before labor begins:

What is false labor?

Your uterus may contract on and on before "true" labor begins. These irregular contractions are called false labor or Braxton Hicks

contractions. They are normal but can be painful at times. You might notice them more at the end of the day.

How can I tell the difference between true labor and false labor?

Usually, false labor contractions are less regular and not as strong as true labor. Sometimes the only way to tell the difference is by having

a vaginal exam to look for changes in your cervix that signal the onset of labor.

One good way to tell the difference is to time the contractions. Note how long it is from the start of one contraction to the start of the

next one. Keep a record for an hour. It may be hard to time labor pains accurately if the contractions are slight.

Please go to the hospital if:

- your water breaks
- you bleed like a period
- your baby is not moving or not moving well
- you have painful contractions 5 minutes apart for an hour
- any fever over 101

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Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

If you have an after hours EMERGENCY or when you are in labor call (281) 557-0300

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The 5-1-1 Rule: Contractions every 5 minutes, lasting 1 minute, for at least 1 hour → time to go to the hospital.